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‘This type of big, communal sporting event has been missing for a long time here.’

MAT ELLIS, at City Hall Plaza with his dad

Pitch perfect fan fest



ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

Chiara Farronato celebrated on City Hall Plaza with her husband and children after Canada scored during a Friday match.

By Chris Serres
and Michael Silverman

GLOBE STAFF

Beneath a thick blanket of humidity, thousands of soccer faithful poured into City Hall Plaza on Friday, turning the brick expanse into a sea of vibrant soccer jerseys, national flags, and a crescendo of soccer chants.

With that energy, the crowd officially christened Boston's World Cup Fan Festival — a free, 16-day event that has all the signs of becoming the epicenter of soccer euphoria for local fans who are priced out from the seven games at Boston Stadium in Foxborough. Nearly 150,000 people have registered, though capacity will be limited to 5,000 attendees at any one time.

Early Friday afternoon, the air was soupy but the mood was buoyant as throngs of soccer fans — including scores of Scots in tartan kilts — made their way up the steps of City Hall, past a phalanx of police officers, and toward the opening gates of the festival. More than 200 people were standing in line by the time the gates officially opened at 2 p.m. — an

Residents and visitors connect and celebrate at city's World Cup event



Team player

A young cancer survivor from Watertown will be a flag bearer at today's World Cup match. **B1.**

hour before Canada was set to square off against Bosnia-Herzegovina in what turned into a 1-1 draw.

The sound of bagpipes, being played by a family of visiting Scots near City Hall, wafted over the procession.

The start of the festival appeared to go as smoothly as organizers had hoped. The entrance line moved quickly. Some were denied entry because their bags weren't clear, but volunteers steered them toward a nearby Target to get the right kind. By the time Canada and Bosnia-Herzegovina took the pitch, the crowd had settled into a comfortable, easy rhythm. Across City Hall Plaza, young children juggled and chased soccer balls across the brick expanse under the approving eyes of adults who looked eager to join in.

Those seeking a break from the afternoon heat moved to the shaded perimeter. Nearby, a bustling play zone kept the youngest fans occupied.

"It definitely exceeded my expectations," said Mat Ellis, 27, an engineer from Boston

FAN FEST, Page A10

Man attributes his bomb threats to childhood abuse

Lawyer says client targeted Everett official because of trauma from long-ago incidents

By Stephanie Ebbert

GLOBE STAFF

EVERETT — When this city's longest-serving elected official was targeted in online bomb and death threats in September, residents were rattled but mystified.

It was the same week conservative commentator Charlie Kirk was assassinated, and no one was taking threats of political violence lightly.

But City Councilor Wayne Matewsky was little known beyond this gritty city, a former bricklayer and bar owner who had been reelected regularly over 46 years.

Now, the man who threatened him has offered an explosive explanation.

Scott Merchant, 37, a Salisbury man who grew up in Everett, told both the Globe and the Middlesex district attorney's office that Matewsky sexually abused him when he was a child. His allegations are also included in a sentencing memo his lawyer filed Wednesday in Essex Superior Court, where Merchant is charged with a felony bomb threat and a related misdemeanor.

Merchant and his lawyer, Ernie

Stone, said he never intended to carry out his threats, and he didn't have the guns or explosives he referenced on social media. His posts, they said, were the manifestation of a mental health crisis triggered by resurfaced trauma from childhood sexual abuse.

"I had no intention [of hurting him]. My intention was to create awareness," Merchant told the Globe. "I crossed a line."

Both Merchant and one of his

ABUSE, Page A6

For Trump's birthday, a cake, it appears, is no longer enough

Last year, a military parade; this year, a UFC spectacle

By Jim Puzzanghera

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — In his first term, President Trump treated his birthday like just another day.

"We'll have a little piece of cake tonight," he told the hosts of "Fox & Friends" on his birthday in 2019 after he was asked how he'd mark turning 73 years old. Trump said he planned to work — it was a Friday — and "I don't have time to celebrate."

That was the norm during his first four years in the White House: no glitzy events or public spectacles on June 14.

But in Trump's second term, his birthday has taken on a holiday-like significance in and around the White

House.

Last year, he finally got the military parade down Constitution Avenue that he wanted in his first term — and it was held on his birthday.

And this Sunday, Trump will commemorate his 80th birthday with an extravaganza unlike anything ever held on the White House grounds: a night of seven Ultimate Fighting Championship mixed martial arts matches in a makeshift Octagon arena on the South Lawn under an elaborate, light-emitting structure known as "the claw" that looks like a red-white-and-blue spaceship.

"I think his ego is out of control," said Representative Jim McGovern, a Worcester Democrat. "Everything has to be about him."

Trump, a lover of military hardware and UFC fights, says the timing of his second-term birthday events is just a coincidence.

TRUMP, Page A7



CHRISTIAN KANTOSKY FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE



Artist David Hockney (left) has died at 88. His paintings turned attention to figurative and narrative art. **C10.**

A federal judge has dismissed three key parts of former WBZ-TV news anchor Kate Merrill's discrimination lawsuit. **D1.**

Shore, shore

Saturday: Sunny, hot. High: 87-92. Low: 67-72.
Sunday: Much the same. Sunrise: 5:07 Sunset: 8:22
Comics and Weather, **D4-5.**

TITLE TIME FOR HIGH SCHOOL ATHLETES

Captain Cailyn Durand lifted the trophy in front of fans after Joseph Case won the MIAA Division 3 softball championship at Worcester State University. Several MIAA titles were decided on Friday. **Sports, C1, 6-7.**

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